

the youngsters joining the BPO industry not doing so today just for the short-term, but are looking at it as a serious career. High salaries are an added bonus, with the pay cheques of some mid-level BPO employees exceeding Rs 50,000 a month. But even as the industry matures, it grapples with a host of problems, which include not just dealing with high attrition and employee stress, but also rising wages and scarcity of skilled workers.

In many ways the meteoric rise

\$20

BILLION IS ESTIMATED
TO BE THE WORTH OF
THE IT AND BPO
INDUSTRY AT PRESENT

2,62,000

NUMBER OF
PROFESSIONALS THE
OUTSOURCING INDUSTRY
WILL BE SHORT OF BY
2012 DUE TO HIGH
ATTRITION RATES

of the BPO industry has paralled the growth of its employees. Take Sharma. When he joined IBM Daksh in 2003, he was unsure of what he wanted to do. He was the quintessential small-town boy, who had come from Punjab to get a college degree (in his case, in computer application from Indira Gandhi National Open University) and then work. He started as an entry-level customer care executive and in two years was promoted to a quality analyst, where he was analysing and monitoring calls. A year later, he was handling a team of seven people. Today Sharma has been moved to the company's corporate office, where he is undergoing training and development programmes. He has a coveted bike and hangs around Gurgaon malls like many of his friends. His job profile has become a sought after one, with the industry not only expanding but becoming one that gives youngsters like Sharma an identity of their own—one that many are seeking.

PLAY SCHOOLS

Bhopal | MADHYA PRADESH



Blackboard jungle

Little India's waking up to education as pricey play schools reflect growing parental aspirations

■ By Ambreesh Mishra

Every day at noon, Prabdeep Kaur rushes to pick up her three-and-a-half year old daughter, Harishi, from Jack & Jill, a swish play school. Come rain or shine, the 28-year-old makes sure Harshi at-

tends school, believing that the foundation school her daughter attends will give her a head start in life. "We learnt by rote, they do it in an informal atmosphere. It makes a world of difference," says Vijay Kamdar, 26, who runs an apparel outlet at the

upmarket number 10 market in Bhopal.

It's a phenomenon that has caught on even in obscure small towns like Pipariya in the Narmada Valley where aspiring young businessmen and traders want playschools for their children. The town has a population of about 80,000 but a thriving trade in arhar dal has created a number of millionaires. "It's the element of aspiration at work. The town has no less than 200 families we can describe as new-money crorepatists. They want the best for their children now," says B.G. Vyas, a doctor and social worker in Pipariya where BMWs, Toyotas and Chevrolet SUVs come dime a dozen. "We joke at times that now Pipariya only needs a Rolls Royce and a good school to be put on the map," says Vyas.

What is an annual tuition fee of Rs 5,000 after all, if it allows a child to hit the fast track? "A pittance really," says Kamdar. With education becoming more competitive and getting a place in an upmarket school a challenge, a head start is what parents are gunning for.



PLAY TIME: Prabdeep with Harshi

PANKAJ TIWARI